Resurrection and Ascension

Mark 16; Luke 24; John 20–21; 1 Corinthians 15; Acts 1

The big idea: On the third day the tomb was empty. The risen Jesus appeared to Mary, to the disciples, to Thomas, and to more than five hundred at once, in a real body with the scars still in it. His resurrection is God's verdict that his payment for sin was enough, the defeat of death, and the firstfruits of ours. Then he ascended to reign, intercede, and send the Spirit.

Before you meet: Read

Mark 16:1–8 | John 20:11–29 | Luke 24:36–53 | 1 Corinthians 15:3–22 | Acts 1:1–11

Open (5 minutes)

Have you ever lost all hope about something and then had it turned around? What happened?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Why do you seek the living among the _____? He is not here, but has risen." *(Luke 24:5–6)*

"Do not disbelieve, but _____." *(John 20:27)*

"Blessed are those who have not _____ and yet have believed." *(John 20:29)*

"Who was delivered up for our trespasses and raised for our _____." *(Romans 4:25)*

"But in fact Christ has been raised from the dead, the _____ of those who have fallen asleep." *(1 Corinthians 15:20)*

"This Jesus, who was taken up from you into heaven, will _____ in the same way as you saw him go into heaven." *(Acts 1:11)*

Discuss

1. Why does it matter that women were the first witnesses to the empty tomb? *Mark 16:1–8; John 20:11–18*

2. Jesus ate fish and showed his scars. Why does it matter that his resurrection body was real and physical? *Luke 24:36–43; John 20:27*

3. Paul says if Christ has not been raised, our faith is futile. Why is the resurrection so central? *1 Corinthians 15:14–20*

4. Jesus restored Peter after his denial. What does that say to someone who has failed Jesus badly? *John 21:15–17*

5. The disciples returned from the ascension with great joy. Why would Jesus leaving make them joyful? *Luke 24:50–53; John 16:7*

6. Jesus asked Martha, Do you believe this? How would you answer him today? *John 11:25–26; Romans 10:9*

Apply this week

Read Mark 16:1–8, Luke 24, and John 20–21 this week. List the reasons for believing the resurrection happened and pick the one that is strongest to you. If you have failed Jesus, hear his question to Peter, Do you love me? and answer him.

Memory verse

"I am the resurrection and the life. Whoever believes in me, though he die, yet shall he live, and everyone who lives and believes in me shall never die."

John 11:25–26

Pray

Praise the risen Lord who holds the keys of death. Thank him that his resurrection proves his payment was enough. If you belong to him, bring one specific need to him as your interceding High Priest, and thank him that he is with you always.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 22

Resurrection and Ascension

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read John 20:11–29 aloud together. Then read 1 Corinthians 15:3–8, 20.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 2, 3, and 6 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the He Appeared timeline and the What the Ascended Jesus Is Doing Now chart in the full lesson.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 23 (Acts 1–4 and 9–10).

Main points to land

1. The tomb was empty and the risen Jesus appeared to many witnesses over forty days, including more than five hundred at once (1 Corinthians 15:3–8; Acts 1:3).
2. His resurrection body was real and physical, scarred and yet never to die (Luke 24:39–43; John 20:27).
3. The resurrection is God's verdict that Christ's payment was enough; all joined to him by faith share that verdict (Romans 4:25; 1 Corinthians 15:17).
4. Christ's resurrection defeats death and is the firstfruits of the resurrection of all who belong to him (1 Corinthians 15:20, 42–44, 55; Hebrews 2:14–15).
5. Jesus ascended bodily and now reigns, intercedes, sends the Spirit, prepares a place, and will come again (Ephesians 1:20–22; Hebrews 7:25; Acts 1:11).

Core doctrine to teach

The Resurrection and Ascension CORE DOCTRINE 22 OF 26

Jesus rose bodily from the dead on the third day. He ascended into heaven in that same body and now reigns at the Father's right hand. His resurrection is God's seal on his finished work and the promise that all who belong to him will rise too. *1 Corinthians 15:3–8, 20; Acts 1:9–11; Romans 4:25; Ephesians 1:20–22*

Answer key (Observe)

1. dead
2. believe
3. seen
4. justification
5. firstfruits
6. come

Questions people will ask

Couldn't the disciples have stolen the body or imagined seeing Jesus?
Frightened men hiding behind locked doors became bold witnesses, and several were killed rather than deny what they had seen. Hundreds saw him, some at once and many still alive when Paul wrote (1 Corinthians 15:6). People do not die for a story they know they made up, and group visions of a man who eats fish do not happen.

Will everyone be raised from the dead?
Yes. Scripture says all will be raised, some to everlasting life and some to shame and everlasting contempt (Daniel 12:2; Acts 17:31). For those who belong to Christ, resurrection means a glorious body like his (Philippians 3:21). That is why Jesus asks, Do you believe this?

Where is Jesus now, and is he still human?
He ascended bodily and reigns at God's right hand as a real man, in the same body, now glorified (Acts 1:9–11; WSC 28). He intercedes for his people (Hebrews 7:25) and is with us by his Spirit (Matthew 28:20).

Why do the Gospel accounts differ in details?
Independent witnesses always remember different details: how many women, which angel spoke, who arrived first. The core is the same in every account: the tomb was empty, and Jesus appeared alive. Differences in detail are what we expect from real testimony, not from a coordinated invention.

Closing prayer

Risen Lord Jesus, you are the resurrection and the life. Thank you that you broke the power of death, that your rising proves your payment was enough, and that you reign at the Father's right hand. Bring failures back as you brought back Peter. Give us faith without seeing, and the hope of a resurrection like yours. Amen.